Orientation topics VITA Mountain View Library

Last updated February 1 2023 by site coordinators

Please read before your first shift. Feel free to add comments to this doc or email mvlibraryvita@gmail.com

1. You will be **assigned one client at a time** by the site coordinators or Greeters. We will try to assign quality reviews to the most experienced volunteers. When you have finished with a client, tell a Greeter so they update the status of that client in their list.

2. For **new VITA volunteers**, at the beginning of your first shift we will try to have you **sit next to** an experienced volunteer and look at their laptop screen when they prepare a return for a client. After observing an experienced volunteer then we will try to assign you a client and have an experienced volunteer observe you. You are welcome to observe several volunteers since each has their own style. For the first few weeks, during the times you are not assigned a client then we suggest you observe an experienced volunteer.

3. We encourage you to get a second opinion and **ask each other questions**. If you think something is not in scope or you are uncomfortable then tell a site coordinator.

4. If a **library computer** freezes or has an issue then tell a site coordinator so we can track it. Please always use Google **Chrome web browser** instead of Internet Explorer. If the computer will not launch the library desktop click on the wifi icon (next to the time in the bottom right corner) make sure the wi-fi is connected to “MobileCartPSK” not “cmvlib”

5. We have a lot of clients where it is not totally clear what is the **last name**. This is true especially with Spanish surnames but we have also seen big mistakes with Chinese names. The best way is to check with the last year return, if available. Otherwise, double check with the client. If the last name on the return doesn’t match what the IRS has then the return will be rejected by the IRS. If you’re unsure, add a note in TaxSlayer with all the information you have including every word on the SS card so if it is rejected we can try to correct it.

6. When you prepare a return:
    a. When preparing the return into the Taxslayer **efile area** and enter in information on the 3rd page of 13614 which includes direct deposit bank numbers and survey questions (demographics, etc)... The transmit to IRS feature will be disabled for everyone except the site coordinators.
    b. When you have finished preparing the return check “**ready for review**” into the eFile area**.**

7. When you do a **quality review**:
    a. Double check everything (13614, SS card) was entered into TaxSlayer correctly.
    b. Print the entire return using the **“MV Library Print Set”**
    c. Walk the client through the main pages of the return.
    d. Have the client **sign the Federal and CA efile authorizations** (2 of each so 4 total).
    e. Give the client the printed tax returns, efile authorizations (1 of each) and all of their docs back.
    f. Add a check mark for the “**ready to transmit”** tag, click the “**Approved**” button, then the “**Complete**” checkbox.
    g. Give the 13614 and efile authorizations (1 of each) to a Greeter. We shred the 13614 and efile forms after the return has been accepted by the IRS and CA.
    h. If you make a significant change during QR then tell the original Tax Preparer about the change.

8. If a return can not be completed during the session and the client leaves then write a reason in the **Notes area in Taxslayer.** That way site coordinators can look through returns and understand why the client left. Also tell a Greeter or a site coordinator the name of the client and why we could not complete the return.

9. To **print** click the print button and then **click to allow blocked pop ups**. It is on the right edge of the website URL field.

10. If a client is **missing a physical form** then they can show it to you on their phone or they can stay in the room and **borrow one of the library laptops** to try to log in and get the form and print it on our printer. It is not possible to print from a phone. If a client asks how to connect to the library wifi then tell them to connect to the Wi-Fi network, cmvlib then accept the Terms of Use (automatically displays on the default browser).

11. If a client says they attended **college** but doesn't have the **1098-T** then ask them to log into the college site and show you the 1098-T so you can verify any scholarship or expenses.

12. If a client has a **1099** from **Uber** but not the Uber account web page that lists the miles and fees then ask the client to log into Uber and show you the account web page.

13. If the client asks for an electronic copy of their tax return then say the IRS doesn't allow us to email tax returns. But their phone probably has an app (Drive from Google) that can take photos and convert to PDF. If a client pushes really hard to have us email then you can download the return to the library laptop and tell the client if they log into the email website on the library computer then they can attach the return to an email they compose to themselves. We do not recommend this since their social security number is in the return.

14. Remember it is your responsibility to write on the 13614 to fix an "unsure" or "blank" boxes and also fill in for each dependent the question in the "To be completed by a Certified Volunteer Preparer"

15. We encourage you to take a **break** between clients. If you leave the room then log out of TaxSlayer. If you want to **eat** inside then there is a break room with refrigerator and table on the second floor. Ask a Greeter for the cardkey.

16. There are two **shifts** on Saturdays. 70% of volunteers start at 10 am and the rest start between 12:30 and 1pm. Those that start on the 10 am shift we ask you to plan on staying until at least 1:00 but you're welcome to stay longer if you want. The first few weeks we'll probably have fewer clients so if you want to enter shift early than just ask a site coordinator.

17. If you are going to miss a week please try to tell us the week before.

18. If a client has a low battery on their phone we have two charging cables they can use. Ask Greeters.

19. If the IRS posts a Volunteer Tax Alert we will send it to you and you should read it before your next session.

20. **ITINs**: If a client has an ITIN then there is no CA healthcare mandate. If you are entering a W2 TaxSlayer will require you to enter in a SSN. Enter what is on the form not the ITIN.

21. **California references**:
    a. To be eligible for the CA Renters Credit the client must have rented for at least 6 months

b. CA Middle Class Tax Refund Help
c. CA Health care mandate: If the client did not have healthcare (or Medi-Cal) for all 12 months
d. CA Individual Shared Responsibility Penalty Estimator: If TaxSlayer shows a CA penalty for not having health care then you can double check the amount owed by using this estimator.
e. If you have CA questions, then a good place is: https://www.ftb.ca.gov/file/personal/index.html
f. CA FTB 5130 VITA Volunteer Manual

CA Middle Class Tax Refund

22. This FTB MCTR page says: *"Individuals who received a California Middle Class Tax Refund (MCTR) of **$600 or more will receive a 1099-MISC** for this payment. ... The MCTR payment is not taxable for California state income tax purposes. You **do not need to claim** the payment as income on your California income tax return. .... Individuals who received an MCTR payment of $600 or more but did not receive a 1099-MISC should **wait until February 15**, 2023, to receive through mail"*
23. If a client has a **MCTR 1099-MISC or they say they received MCTR we should enter it into TaxSlayer.** If the IRS issues a statement that MCTR is not taxable then a site-coordinator will tell tax preparers. If you want to exclude MCTR from the CA then in the CA return click "**Subtractions from Income**" then click "**Other Subtractions**" and write "MCTR Payment" (or something similar) for the description.

24. If a client says they did not receive the **CA Middle Class Tax Refund** tell them there is nothing we can do to help since the eligibility is entirely based on 2020 tax returns that already need to have been filed *"Amending or filing your 2020 tax return after …February 15, 2022,... will not qualify taxpayers for the MCTR payment." "If you believe you are eligible to receive a payment and have not received it by February 14, 2023, call the customer support number listed in the Contact information section."*If clients have more question you can tell them they can learn more at the FTB site: www.ftb.ca.gov/MCTR
We also created the below handout that you can give clients. The Greeters have a few copies.

To learn about the California Middle Class Tax Refund go to: www.ftb.ca.gov/MCTR

If you believe you are eligible to receive a payment and have not received it by February 14, 2023, call the customer support number:

Chat
Available at mctrpayment.com
Weekdays, 8AM to 5PM

Customer support
800-542-9332
Weekdays, 8AM to 5PM

Debit card questions
Assistance with activation, replacement, lost, or stolen card
800-240-0223
Card activation available 24/7
Customer support available weekdays, 8AM to 10PM

Online
mctrpayment.com

You are eligible if you meet all of the requirements, some of which are:

- Filed your **2020 tax return by October 15, 2021**
- Were not eligible to be claimed as a dependent in the 2020 tax year
- Were a California resident for six months or more of the 2020 tax year

Payments are expected to be issued between October 2022 and January 2023.
Generally, direct deposit payments will be made to eligible taxpayers who e-filed their 2020 CA tax return and received their CA tax refund by direct deposit. Deposit is named "FTB MCT REFUND MCT REFUND."
MCTR debit card payments will be mailed to the remaining eligible taxpayers in an envelope like:

